killing in the name of blasphemy is already a problem that the state has been unable to control, as evident in the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) 2016 and the Amnesty International 2016 reports. Instead of curtailing or amending the blasphemy laws that legitimize the criminalization of speech deemed blasphemous to the extent that individuals take the law into their own hands as in the killing of Salman Taseer, Shama and Shahzad Masih, Mashal Khan and countless others, the state has 'weaponized' this law. Such actions could be perceived as PML(N)'s attempt to pander to a deepening conservatism within Pakistani society for votes in the elections of 2018, but whatever the rationale behind such policing, the PML(N) has widened the scope for these laws to be abused.

Furthermore, the extent to which young people are truly active online varies among individuals, with the majority of young people using social media sites such as Facebook to connect with friends and family both in Pakistan and abroad; the level of political activism is often limited to an online comment or reading the news. Such activism will not gain momentum, especially given the responses of participants who feel threatened by the actions of the state, which have only worsened after the implementation of PECA 2016. However, with PTM gaining traction and social media promoting the movement while broadcasting channels are prevented from doing so, demonstrates the potential of social media as a medium to garner support for indigenous, civil rights movements.

Ironically, social media can also be a platform for greater engagement between the state and its citizens. But the persistence of 'fear' that Durrani et al. (2015) alluded to continues to influence state–citizen interaction online. It is a space where citizens can express dissent, or voice opposition against the state and the security apparatus, but also where the state through its direct interaction can ensure greater transparency and effectiveness in governance. The internet and social media have the potential to become an important tool in strengthening the state–citizen relationship. Yet, given the global nature of the World Wide Web, the citizen can also become a potential threat to the state, transcending boundaries and physical spaces, in communication with a global audience. In Pakistan the internet, and in particular social media, has become yet another space to be controlled, through which the state denies its citizens freedom of speech and protest (Digital Rights Foundation 2015; HRW 2017), upholding a national narrative that citizens are forced to blindly follow.